Worksheet A: The Counting Path

Name: _____ Date: _____

Task 1: The counting path

in class, individual work, 8 min.

Silently choose a number between 1 and 10. Count that many words from the beginning of the text; this is your starting word. Count its letters and move on exactly that many words. Repeat. Punctuation, including apostrophes, does not count. If the next jump would take you beyond the end of the text, your current word is your **final word**. Keep it to yourself. *(Text written for this exercise, fictitious story.)*

When Hanna Berger first walked into the old library of her town, she was looking for one single book. Her aunt had told her that it held a report about the winter in which the lake froze over completely and people could walk across to the other side with dry feet. Hanna wanted to know whether this story was true. She asked the librarian, a quiet man with a grey beard, where she should begin. He smiled and gave her no title, only a piece of advice: "Start anywhere, but write down where each book sends you." So she began with a chronicle of the local fishermen. In it she found a reference to old church registers that recorded every baptism and every burial. In the margin of the church registers there was a note about unusual cold, with a reference to the weather records of a teacher. The teacher had measured the temperature every morning and written it into small notebooks. These notebooks lay in the cellar, in a box labelled "Miscellaneous". Hanna worked for three weeks at a long table under a high window. She read, compared and took notes, and sometimes she found statements that contradicted each other. A merchant wrote that the ice had been thin, a priest claimed that people had danced on it. Hanna learned that every witness had his own reasons for claiming something. She sorted the reports by date, by origin and by the question of who could have seen what. In the end almost all traces, no matter where she had started, led to the same place. It was a thin notebook of the teacher, which listed many nights of hard frost for one February, and next to them a sentence in neat handwriting: "Today I walked with my pupils across the ice to the far shore." Hanna put down her pen. She now knew that her aunt's story had a true core, and she knew something else as well: whoever searches long and carefully often arrives at the same source.

My starting number: _____ My final word: _____ Number of jumps: _____